

IN THE LABYRINTH of Bollywood's male-dominated world of directors and storytellers, Zoya Akhtar is indeed part of a rare breed. With her soul-stirring films like *Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara* (2011) and *Gully Boy* (2019), Akhtar has left an indelible mark on Indian cinema. In addition to her work as a director and screenwriter, she is a well-known film producer. With Director Reema Kagti of *Talaash* fame, she co-founded the film production company Tiger Baby in October 2015 with the aim of telling distinctive stories and have more nuanced characters in mainstream cinema.

Since its debut production *Gully Boy*—directed by Akhtar—that premiered at the Berlin International Film Festival, Tiger Baby has been making waves under her watchful eyes, especially in the OTT space. While *Dahaad* and *Made in Heaven 2*, that released on Amazon Prime Video in May and August, respectively, became the gold standard with strong female and LGBTQ+ characters, its latest offering, *The Archies* on Netflix, is yet another feather in Akhtar's cap. Thanks to these and many other wins this past year, she has made her comeback to *BT*'s Most Powerful Women in Business list after a gap of four years.

But hold on, there is more. Akhtar is already thinking about business diversification. Tiger Baby has joined hands with musician Ankur Tewari to launch an audio label, Tiger Baby Records. The label aims to delve into the diverse soundscapes of the subcontinent and represent them globally. She says the vision is to create albums, EPs (extended plays) and singles, music-driven documentaries, podcasts and live events and is collaborating with a vast array of artists to create fresh musical projects.

Akhtar has a diploma in filmmaking from the illustrious New

THE TRAILBLAZER

Zoya Akhtar has successfully demonstrated her commitment towards diverse narratives while juggling the roles of writer, director and producer

BY PRERNA LIDHOO

WHY SHE MATTERS

She stands out for her contribution to distinctive storytelling, empowering female characters, thus fostering a more inclusive cinematic landscape and contributing to the evolution of Indian cinema



York University. After that, she worked as an assistant to directors like Tony Gerber, Dev Benegal, and Mira Nair before she went on to become a writer-director.

She is not done yet. Akhtar has also launched the company's new advertising cell, Tiger Telly, in April 2023. Through this, Akhtar says, she is looking at creating short-form content ranging from TV and digital video commercials to music videos and brand films while maintaining a high standard of innovative and visually compelling storytelling. Tiger Telly recently launched its first commercial for the used-car sales platform Spinny, starring Indian cricketing greats



ZOYA AKHTAR

51, Director and Co-founder, Tiger Baby

Sachin Tendulkar, Anil Kumble, and Yuvraj Singh. "As a studio, we aim to tell stories across all formats, and this campaign helped set that up beautifully," Akhtar says. Tiger Telly's services include scripting, treatment development, and final edit deliverables ready for distribution. Through Tiger Baby, Akhtar seeks to put herself out there as a champion of strong characters, showcasing her commitment to diverse narratives that have successfully established her as a trailblazer in a film industry that is witnessing considerable churn. **BT**

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